

GOD AND MAN

IN THE OLD TESTAMENT



LEON ROTH

GEORGE ALLEN AND UNWIN
THE MACMILLAN COMPANY

ETHICAL AND RELIGIOUS CLASSICS
OF EAST AND WEST
NO. 12

GOD AND MAN
IN THE OLD TESTAMENT

ETHICAL AND RELIGIOUS CLASSICS OF EAST AND WEST

RŪMĪ: POET AND MYSTIC

by Reynold A. Nicholson

SUFISM

by A. J. Arberry

THE POETRY AND CAREER OF LI PO

by Arthur Waley

SAINT FRANCIS IN ITALIAN PAINTING

by George Kaftal

THE MYSTICS OF SPAIN

by E. Allison Peers

SONGS OF ZARATHUSHTRA

by Dastur Framrose Ardeshir Bode
and Piloo Nanavutty

AKBAR'S RELIGIOUS THOUGHT

by Emmy Wellesz

THE FAITH AND PRACTICE OF AL-GHAZALI

by W. Montgomery Watt

THE HOLY KORAN

by A. J. Arberry

PLOTINUS

by A. H. Armstrong

THE THOUGHT OF THE PROPHETS

by Israel Mattuck

Bible. tr. English. Selections. 1955.

GOD AND MAN

IN THE OLD TESTAMENT

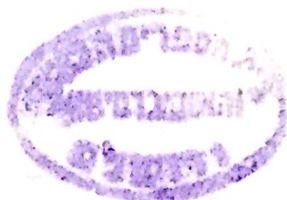
by

LEON ROTH

D.Phil., F.B.A.

בית ציוני אמריקה בישראל
ספריה ע"ש גרשון ויזמן
רח' דניאל פריש 1 תל-אביב
20 ISRAEL
ADAM GOLDSTEIN LIBRARY
1, DANIEL FRISCH STR. TEL-AVIV

LONDON: GEORGE ALLEN & UNWIN LTD
NEW YORK: THE MACMILLAN COMPANY



FIRST PUBLISHED IN 1955

This book is copyright under the Berne Convention. Apart from any fair dealing for the purposes of private study, research, criticism or review, as permitted under the Copyright Act 1911, no portion may be reproduced by any process without written permission. Enquiry should be made to the publisher.

© George Allen & Unwin Ltd.

S55 B269

221.2

R

184
m.v. 481

PRINTED IN GREAT BRITAIN
BY C. TINLING AND CO. LTD
LIVERPOOL, LONDON AND PRESCOT

To the memory of
J. L. MAGNES

'For Zion's sake will I not hold my peace'

בית ציוני אמריקה בישראל
ספריה ע"ש אברהם גולדשטיין
רח' דניאל פריש 1 תל-אביב

ZION IN ISRAEL
ABRAHAM GOLDSTEIN LIBRARY
1, DANIEL FRISCH STR. TEL-AVIV

In some five hundred passages ranging in length from half verses to whole chapters, this Biblical anthology attempts to bring together, in their original wording, the highest expressions of the Biblical view of life with its hopes, its promises, its obligations and, together with them, its sanctions and its warnings.

The anthology follows a plan and method of its own. It is non-historical and non-doctrinal and rests on the conviction that great literature is adequate to all times and all occasions. It starts with the confrontations of man with God as seen in the 'calls' of the prophets, and proceeds to the ways of life demanded of man and the duties accompanying the privilege of vocation. It ends with the visions of the ideal society which in times of trial like the present have always served to sustain the mind.

GENERAL INTRODUCTION

AS A RESULT of two Wars that have devastated the World men and women everywhere feel a twofold need. We need a deeper understanding and appreciation of other peoples and their civilizations, especially their moral and spiritual achievements. And we need a wider vision of the Universe, a clearer insight into the fundamentals of ethics and religion. How ought men to behave? How ought nations? Does God exist? What is His Nature? How is He related to His creation? Especially, how can man approach Him? In other words, there is a general desire to know what the greatest minds, whether of East or West, have thought and said about the Truth of God and of the beings who (as most of them hold) have sprung from Him, live by Him, and return to Him.

It is the object of this Series, which originated among a group of Oxford men and their friends, to place the chief ethical and religious masterpieces of the world, both Christian and non-Christian, within easy reach of the intelligent reader who is not necessarily an expert—the ex-Service man who is interested in the East, the undergraduate, the adult student, the intelligent public generally. The Series will contain books of three kinds: translations, reproductions of ideal and religious art, and background books showing the surroundings in which the literature and art arose and developed. These books overlap each other. Religious art, both in East and West, often illustrates a religious text, and in suitable cases the text and the pictures will be printed together to complete each other. The background books will often consist largely of translations. The volumes will be

prepared by scholars of distinction, who will try to make them, not only scholarly, but intelligible and enjoyable. This Introduction represents the views of the General Editors as to the scope of the Series, but not necessarily the views of all contributors to it. The contents of the books will also be very varied—ethical and social, biographical, devotional, philosophic and mystical, whether in poetry, in pictures or in prose. There is a great wealth of material. Confucius lived in a time much like our own, when State was at war with State and the people suffering and disillusioned; and the 'Classics' he preserved or inspired show the social virtues that may unite families, classes and States into one great family, in obedience to the Will of Heaven. Asoka and Akbar (both of them great patrons of art) ruled a vast Empire on the principles of religious faith. There are the moral anecdotes and moral maxims of the Jewish and Muslim writers of the Middle Ages. There are the beautiful tales of courage, love and fidelity in the Indian and Persian epics. Shakespeare's plays show that he thought the true relation between man and man is love. Here and there a volume will illustrate the unethical or less ethical man and difficulties that beset him.

Then there are the devotional and philosophic works. The lives and legends (legends often express religious truth with clarity and beauty) of the Buddha, of the parents of Mary, of Francis of Assisi, and the exquisite sculptures and paintings that illustrate them. Indian and Christian religious music, and the words of prayer and praise which the music intensifies. There are the prophets and apocalyptic writers, Zarathustrian and Hebrew; the Greek philosophers, Christian thinkers—and the Greek, Latin, medieval and modern—whom they so deeply influenced. There is, too, the Hindu, Buddhist and Christian teaching expressed in such great

monuments as the Indian temples, Barabudur (the Chartres of Asia) and Ajanta, Chartres itself and the Sistine Chapel.

Finally, there are the mystics of feeling, and the mystical philosophers. In God-loving India the poets, musicians, sculptors and painters inspired by the spiritual worship of Krishna and Rama, as well as the philosophic mystics from the Upanishads onward. The two great Taoists Lao-tze and Chuang-tze and the Sung mystical painters in China, Rumi and other sufis in Islam, Plato and Plotinus, followed by 'Dionysius', Eckhart, St. John of the Cross and (in our view) Dante and other great mystics and mystical painters in many Christian lands.

Mankind is hungry, but the feast is there, though it is locked up and hidden away. It is the aim of this Series to put it within reach, so that, like the heroes of Homer, we may stretch forth our hands to the good cheer laid before us.

No doubt the great religions differ in fundamental respects. But they are not nearly so far from one another as they seem. We think they are further off than they are largely because we so often misunderstand and misrepresent them. Those whose own religion is dogmatic have often been as ready to learn from other teachings as those who are liberals in religion. Above all, there is an enormous amount of common ground in the great religions, concerning, too, the most fundamental matters. There is frequent agreement on the Divine Nature; God is the One, Self-subsisting Reality, knowing Himself, and therefore loving and rejoicing in Himself. Nature and finite spirits are in some way subordinate kinds of Being, or merely appearances of the Divine, the One. The three stages of the way of man's approach or return to God are in essence the

same in Christian and non-Christian teaching: an ethical stage, then one of knowledge and love, leading to the mystical union of the soul with God. Each stage will be illustrated in these volumes.

Something of all this may (it is hoped) be learnt from the books and pictures in this Series. Read and pondered with a desire to learn, they will help men and women to find 'fulness of life', and peoples to live together in greater understanding and harmony. To-day the earth is beautiful, but men are disillusioned and afraid. But there may come a day, perhaps not a distant day, when there will be a renaissance of man's spirit: when men will be innocent and happy amid the beauty of the world, or their eyes will be opened to see that egoism and strife are folly, that the universe is fundamentally spiritual, and that men are the sons of God.

They shall not hurt nor destroy
In all My holy mountain:
For all the earth shall be full of the
knowledge of the Lord
As the waters cover the sea.

THE EDITORS

FOREWORD

This anthology was prompted by the twofold belief that the Hebrew Scriptures have something of importance to communicate and that they can communicate it best themselves. The selection given is not exhaustive. The topics are restricted and within each topic the treatment is far from complete. But it is offered in the hope that it may be suggestive and even, on occasion, helpful. Its material is old, some of it possibly the oldest literature in which mankind has shown continuous interest. But its relevance is renewed with the years. It is what students have learned to call mature. At its best it has achieved a serenity and a penetration which set it both inside and above all situations.

Scholars will gasp at my gay disregard of philological and historical considerations; and I confess to have stitched my cloth as it pleased me, taking sentences, even phrases, from any context that occurred and setting them beside others similarly displaced. This is due not only to ignorance. Literature produces its effect in many ways; and it is just the isolated sentence or detached phrase which sticks in the mind and is called out long after by an appropriate occasion. Ideas germinate unseen; and their first origin is often an unheeded word embedded in the memory fortuitously.

But my motley is a context of its own; and I should ask readers, in the words of Robert Bridges in the Introduction to his Spirit of Man, to 'bathe rather than to fish in these waters'. But I shall quote, if I may, a few whole sentences from this Introduction to the best of all anthologies known to me, in order to explain my own method and approach:

'First then, the reader is invited to bathe rather than to fish in these waters: that is to say, the several pieces are to

be read in context; and it is for this reason that no titles nor names of authors are inserted in the text, because they would distract the attention and lead away the thought and even overrule consideration. Yet, although there is a sequence of context, there is no logical argument: the demonstration is of various moods of mind, which are allowed free play. . . . As for the sequence chosen, that might no doubt have been other than it is without damage and perhaps with advantage; but, as will readily be perceived, the main implication is essential, namely, . . . ?

—but what the implication is in this case I leave to the reader who will, I hope, judge for himself.

*

In the interests of space I have occasionally omitted a few verses from a passage but never in such a way as to alter the sense; and I have always noted the omission in the reference. As a rule, and except when otherwise indicated, I have used the Revised Version of 1884 (text or margin). In the few cases where I have felt compelled to modify it I have indicated the fact by adding an A (=Amended) in brackets after the reference. (M) after a reference means (R.V.) Margin. I should perhaps say that I have found the principal defect of the Revised Version, apart from its lack of divination of future scholarship, its frequent and disturbing changes of the word order of the original. Where I have changed it back I have indicated the fact by the addition to the reference of the letters OA (=Order Amended). But I am afraid that in any case, as was remarked over two thousand years ago, 'things originally spoken in Hebrew have not the same force in them when they are translated into another tongue'.

*

Much modern religion seems to be of the type so happily

described by M. Robert de Traz in his study of Pierre Loti (Hachette, 1948, p. 133):

‘. . . Sa préoccupation religieuse se fait lancinante. Elle lui dicte de nouveaux voyages qui sont moins des explorations de pays inconnus que des pèlerinages à la découverte du divin. C’est maintenant une aventure spirituelle qu’il poursuit.

‘Elle n’aboutira pas; elle ne fera même qu’aggraver sa tristesse, sa déception, son scepticisme. Pourquoi?’

‘C’est que cette quête de la divinité est encore et toujours, chez Loti, une recherche complaisante de lui-même. Il agréera . . . ce qui correspond à ses propres préférences; il n’acceptera pas les exigences . . . Il ambitionne moins d’atteindre à la vérité que de calmer son angoisse latente, sa terreur de la fin qui s’approche, et de trouver enfin moins une certitude peut-être qu’un remède et une consolation.’

It is by contrast with such an attitude as this, so widespread in our time, that the nature of Biblical religion stands out.

Cambridge,
11 March 1954.

L. R.

CONTENTS

GENERAL INTRODUCTION	Page 9
FOREWORD	13
I <i>The Vision of the Almighty</i>	19
II <i>The Knowledge of the Most High</i>	29
III <i>The Everlasting God</i>	36
IV <i>Our Days on the Earth</i>	47
V <i>The God of the Spirits of All Flesh</i>	55
VI <i>In Thee I Trust</i>	67
VII <i>The Path of Life</i>	78
VIII <i>The Ten Words</i>	91
IX <i>Everyone According to his Ways</i>	121
X <i>My People, My Chosen</i>	130
XI <i>The God of Judgement</i>	141
XII <i>A Remnant Shall Return</i>	150
XIII <i>The Vision for the Appointed Time</i>	161
XIV <i>The End of the Matter</i>	168

ETHICAL AND RELIGIOUS CLASSICS OF EAST AND WEST

GENERAL EDITORS:

A. J. ARBERRY, RADHAKRISHNAN, F. W. THOMAS

RŪMĪ, POET AND MYSTIC

by Reynold A. Nicholson

Cr. 8vo. 8s 6d net

SUFISM

by A. J. Arberry

Cr. 8vo. 8s 6d net

SAINT FRANCIS IN ITALIAN PAINTING

by George Kaftal

Demy 8vo. 12s 6d

THE POETRY AND CAREER OF LI PO

by Arthur Waley

Cr. 8vo. 8s 6d net

THE MYSTICS OF SPAIN *by E. Allison Peers*

Cr. 8vo. 9s 6d net

SONGS OF ZARATHUSTRA *by Dastur Framroze*

Ardeshtir Bode and Piloo Nanavutty Cr. 8vo. 8s 6d net

AKBAR'S RELIGIOUS THOUGHT REFLECTED
IN MOGUL PAINTING

by Emmy Wellesz

Demy 8vo. 12s 6d net

THE FAITH AND PRACTICE OF AL-GHAZĀLĪ

by W. Montgomery Watt

THE THOUGHT OF THE PROPHETS

by Rabbi Israel I. Mattuck

Cr. 8vo. 9s 6d net

PLOTINUS

by A. H. Armstrong

Cr. 8vo. 10s

THE HOLY KORAN

by A. J. Arberry

Cr. 8vo. 8s